

CHAPTER: JULIUS CAESAR

Summary

Two thousand years ago, there lived in Rome a great soldier and leader, Julius Caesar, who was famous all over Europe as a conqueror. Caesar's best friend- Brutus also lived there. He was a brave man who had high and noble morals and watched his growing ambitions with great anxiety. Brutus and his brother-in-law, Cassius suspected that Caesar might be offered the crown at the National Games. Cassius was a member of the Roman Party which did not wish Caesar to be announced as the king and he was sent by his companions to persuade Brutus to join them. Casca, another member of Cassius's party, had been at the games. He told them that Mark Antony (another famous soldier and friend of Caesar) had offered the crown three times to Caesar but every time Caesar refused to accept it. Brutus went home disturbed. He could not sleep and wondered how Caesar could be cured of his proud nature and ambitious greed. Casca, Decius and the other members of the party came secretly to see Brutus. Together they discussed their plans i.e. to kill Caesar at the Capitol (the Town Hall) where he was going to give a speech to the people the next day.

The next day was dark and cloudy. There had been thunder and lightning all night along with terrible storms of wind, and the whole earth was shaking and trembling. Calpurnia, Caesar's wife begged him not to go to the Capitol that morning as she had had the most frightening dream. When Decius went to Caesar's home, he heard about Calpurnia's dream. He laughed at her fears and convinced Caesar to go to the Capitol.

Caesar wrapped his cloak around him and went out with Decius. Caesar did not know that his enemies were all around him at the Capitol. One

after another they made some excuses to come up to speak to him until they all stood beside him. They drew their swords and killed Caesar. When Caesar saw that even his dearest friend was against him, he cried out in despair and fell dying on the ground. The killing of Caesar surprised the Roman people. They were filled with fear and confusion. Brutus addressed the frightened people and said, "Romans! Julius Caesar was brave but as he was ambitious, I killed him. I have killed my best friend for the good of Rome, but I have the same sword for myself when it shall please my country to need my death."

After this Mark Antony rose to speak. "The noble Brutus has told you that Caesar was ambitious. If this was so, then it was a terrible fault and he has terribly answered for it. But Brutus says that he was ambitious. Yesterday at the games you all saw me offering him the kingly crown which he refused three times.

Was this ambition? Yet Brutus says that he was ambitious and Brutus is an honourable man." The Romans were moved by his speech and they rose against Brutus. Antony showed them the cloak that was torn by the swords of men whom Caesar thought were his friends. Shouting for revenge, people rushed out of the market place in search of Caesar's murderers. Brutus fled to Greece with his brother-in-law Cassius and then in despair they killed themselves. But then Mark Antony ordered that Brutus should be given a proper burial.

Question / Answers

Q1: Why did a certain party of Romans wish to kill Julius Caesar?

Ans: Julius Caesar, famous all over Europe as a conqueror was admired by his people as a national hero. He returned home victorious from a prolonged battle and Romans cheered him with verve. A certain party of Romans wished to kill him because they felt that Julius Caesar was

getting all the name and fame and power and they were envious of his growing power.

Q2:Why did Calpurnia beg Caesar not to go to the Capitol?

Ans : Calpurnia, Caesar's wife, begged Caesar not to go to the Capitol (The Town Hall) because she had the most frightening dream in which Caesar's statue which stood in the market place had poured forth blood and the Roman people came smiling to wash their hands in it. Someone had seen a lion in the market place, and graves opened and they were giving up the dead. There was the noise of battle in the air, and the cries of men and horses in pain, She was afraid that something terrible was going to happen, so she requested Caesar not to leave home.

Q3:What two reasons did Antony give to show that Caesar was not ambitious?

Ans: Antony, a powerful orator, spoke in favour of Caesar and moulded the Roman people by his speech and the two reasons he gave to show that Caesar was not ambitious were:-

1. Caesar was always kind and generous to the poor. He always felt great love and pity for them.
2. Caesar was offered a kingly crown thrice but he refused it every time which certainly showed that he was not ambitious.

Q4:Why was Brutus' decision to march from Sardis to Philippi wrong?

Ans: Brutus wanted to march to Philippi and attack Mark Antony but Cassius was against it. He wanted to wait for the enemy to come to them. But Brutus persuaded Cassius and they marched to Philippi. Octavius and Mark Antony had the advantage of a good defence position and they also had a well rested army. So, Brutus' decision to march from Sardis to Philippi was wrong.

Q5:Why has Brutus been called 'The Noblest Roman of them all'?

Ans: Brutus was called 'The Noblest Roman of them all' because Antony told his men that whatever they (conspirators) did was in envy of the great Caesar; Brutus was the only one with honest thoughts for the good of the people. He killed Caesar for the good of Rome as he believed that Caesar was becoming ambitious and would do anything for power. So he ordered his soldiers to carry Brutus' body into the camp for an honourable burial.